

EVERYDAY MILLIONAIRE

Brian came from a working-class family he describes as “not rich, but not poor.” His father was a small-business owner and taught Brian the value of work at a young age. He told us that he mowed yards in the summer, shoveled snow in the winter, and washed dishes at a local restaurant as a boy. “If you wanted money, you went to work,” he says. “It’s just what you did.” That solid work ethic and respect for hard-earned money served Brian well, especially after he went through an unexpected career change in his late thirties. After his employer was forced to eliminate his position due to financial reasons, Brian picked himself up, went back to school, and learned an entirely new field. That enabled him to start a second career at a time when many of his friends were at the peak of their success.

Through it all, Brian never earned more than an average middle-class wage, but he also always kept his spending and lifestyle in check. He knew from his father and grandfather that real wealth comes not from a high-paying job but from solid, consistent investments. So, throughout his entire career, Brian lived on 80% of his income and saved the other 20%—no matter what his salary was at any given time. That discipline, commitment, and reasonable lifestyle enabled this normal, middle-class guy to retire early at age fifty-nine with a net worth of over \$2.3 million. When we asked him why more people don’t achieve what he was able to, he said it was simple. “The main things that keep people from becoming millionaires are their spending habits and their saving/spending ratios,” he explains. “If you save 1% and spend 99%, you aren’t going anywhere.” I think *ratios* is the key word here. Brian made the commitment to himself early on to save 20% of his income no matter how much or how little he made. By doing that consistently—always keeping his spending and saving ratios in check—he became a millionaire almost on autopilot.

Despite the images that many people have about millionaires, Brian’s conservative lifestyle and long-term wealth-building plan aren’t that unusual. In fact, that combination of hard work, goal setting, and percentage-based saving is something we saw over and over again in our research.